Military Intelligence [MI]. Some ISI departments focus on collecting and analyzing intelligence, while others conduct covert operations. It's directorate S, or S wing as it is sometimes known, is responsible for external operations and a specialized section within it has traditionally been responsible for working with non-state proxies. Because the ISI is both sprawling and compartmentalized, many units have little knowledge of the activities of those within it tasked to work with militant outfits like Lashkar. Pakistan also boasts two civilian intelligence agencies: the Intelligence Bureau [IB] and the police's Special Branch. The Federal Investigative Agency [FIA] is Pakistan's top criminal investigation agency and the country has established an anti-terrorism force as well. For the sake of simplicity, these various intelligence and investigative agencies are referred to collectively as the security services. Because the ISI is disproportionately powerful relative to these other agencies and plays a special role in coordinating militant groups like Lashkar, at times this book refers to it as a distinct entity.

The US initially shunned Zia, but the Soviet invasion of Afghanistan in December 1979 provided him with a route into America's good graces. It also provided Pakistan a greater opportunity to influence events in Afghanistan, which was deemed necessary for its own security. Pakistan's geographic configuration meant the country lacked strategic depth within its borders should India invade from the east, and it sought to mitigate this by seeking strategic depth in Afghanistan. This necessitated a friendly and pliable government in Kabul, but historically Afghanistan had closer relations with India. Kabul also had designs on border territory inhabited by Pashtun tribes that became part of Pakistan, which feared India's support for these revanchist ambitions.[27] This heightened concerns in Pakistan about the threat of Pashtun separatism on its western border and fed the phobia that its enemies not only surrounded the country, but also sought to dismember it. Pakistan responded by using pan-Islamic sentiment to undercut separatist sentiment among the Pashtun tribes who lived on both sides of the Durand Line that serves as the Afghanistan-Pakistan border, as well as to thwart Indian influence in Afghanistan. This included providing financial and military support to Afghan Islamists beginning in the mid-1970s, a policy initiated before General Zia came to power.[28] The Soviet invasion presented a new threat, as Islamabad feared that if they occupied Afghanistan too easily then it would be a short step to Pakistan. Zia decided